

GRAPHIC DESIGN CAREER ROADMAP

JOB READY BY SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

Prepared **August 14, 2026** · Horizon **7 Weeks** · **BCA Student, Graphic Design Track**

01 Current Position + Target

CURRENT POSITION

BCA student with Canva as the strongest tool today. Photoshop and Illustrator are early-stage. Fundamentals are understood but **not yet applied to real briefs**. AI-assisted design stays a secondary, supporting skill.

TARGET

A **paid internship or entry-level Graphic Design role** by September 30, 2026. The goal is employability, not mastery — enough proof to **compete credibly** for entry-level opportunities in this window.

02 Career Priorities — In Order

1	Fundamentals	Typography, hierarchy, composition and grid systems.
2	Photoshop	Production-level image editing and compositing.
3	Portfolio	The actual proof of employability — nothing else matters without it.
4	Illustrator	Vector and logo work, learned on demand through project need.
5	Resume + LinkedIn	How the portfolio gets seen and taken seriously.
6	Applications + Outreach	The engine that turns readiness into interviews.
7	AI-Assisted Design	Secondary differentiator — one project only, never the main story.

03 Skill Gap

Design Fundamentals Apply fundamentals directly to real briefs. ● Developing	Photoshop Reach production fluency through real projects. ● Early Stage
Portfolio Publish 3 case studies with process shown. ● Not Started	Illustrator Build basic fluency inside a real project. ● Early Stage
Resume + LinkedIn Draft resume, align LinkedIn to design roles. ● Not Started	Applications Run a weekly, repeatable outreach pipeline. ● Not Started

Figma — deferred. Not prioritized this cycle; revisit after employment is secured.

04 What I Need to Fix

- ☐ No finished portfolio case studies
- ☐ Photoshop workflow needs practice
- ☐ Illustrator needs project-based practice
- ☐ No design-focused resume
- ☐ No consistent application pipeline
- ☐ Need stronger applied fundamentals

THE 7-WEEK PATH TO JOB READINESS

AUGUST → SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

01 7-Week Roadmap

WEEK 01	Design Fundamentals	Typography + hierarchy drills
WEEK 02	Photoshop	Image editing project
WEEK 03	Photoshop + Composition	Social media campaign
WEEK 04	Illustrator	Logo / vector project
WEEK 05	Portfolio	Case studies + presentation
WEEK 06	Resume + LinkedIn	Application materials ready
WEEK 07	Applications	Outreach + interviews begin

02 Portfolio Projects

01 · BRAND IDENTITY Logo, Color, Typography, Mockups Proves identity systems and applied consistency.	02 · SOCIAL MEDIA CAMPAIGN 5-7 Consistent Social Designs Proves grid systems and platform-aware layout.
03 · POSTER / EDITORIAL Typography, Hierarchy, Composition Proves print-oriented layout thinking.	04 · AI-ASSISTED DESIGN One Documented AI + Design Workflow Optional differentiator — never the lead project.

03 Application Strategy

Portfolio From Week 5 Build 3 strong case studies that show real design thinking.	Resume + LinkedIn From Week 6 Position yourself specifically for graphic design roles.	Applications + Outreach From Week 6 Apply and contact studios and companies before September ends.
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04 September 30 Checklist

- ☐ 3 strong portfolio case studies
- ☐ Photoshop working fluency
- ☐ Illustrator fundamentals
- ☐ Strong design fundamentals
- ☐ Design-specific resume
- ☐ Updated LinkedIn profile
- ☐ Portfolio published live
- ☐ Active application pipeline

NEXT 7 DAYS

1. Practice typography daily.

2. Practice Photoshop daily.

3. Select first portfolio project.
4. Start the first real design project.

5. Build LinkedIn design positioning.

6. Start documenting work publicly.